

W6OTX

W6ARA

PAARA NEWSLETTER
VOLUME 76, NUMBER 10, October 2025

K6OTA

K6YQT

PAARAgraphs



The Official Newsletter of the

Palo Alto Amateur Radio Association, Inc.

The Friendliest Club Around

Celebrating 88 years as an *active* amateur radio club—Since 1937<http://www.paara.org/>

Building a Station for Satellite & EME Contacts Justin Giorgi, AI6YM

Part how-to, part post-mortem. In this talk I'll take you through building a VHF/UHF station capable of making contacts over satellite repeaters and transponders. It's not as hard as you think, and you probably have the gear already! From your first contact over the Karman line to a moon-bounce mega-station, I'll walk you through the upgrades, design considerations, and pitfalls.

Those that came to Field Day know that I fell into many of those pitfalls myself. I'll go over the successes, the challenges, and (most importantly) the lessons learned building a station for PAARA Field Day.

Bio: Justin is a serial tinkerer and jack of all trades (master of none). His projects aren't meant to be successful by any traditional definition, they're meant to be educational and entertaining.

This meeting will be a Hybrid Meeting Zoom and In Person

Time: Oct 3, 2025 07:00 PM Pacific Time
Please check <https://www.paara.org/> for
Zoom Details

Upcoming Events

Oct 3	PAARA General Meeting,
Nov 7	7:00 PM to ~9:30PM
Dec 5	Zoom and In Person Meeting.
Oct 10-12	Pacificon 2025
Oct 15	Board Meeting, 7:00 PM.
Nov 19	Everyone welcome! Zoom Meeting,
Dec 17	eMail President for details.



President's Corner

I hope everyone had a great time at the PAARA in the Park event in September! We had a great turnout and a fun and successful project. It's nice to know that Rengstorff Park is a good alternate site for park events, but we'll likely hold future events back at Memorial Park in Cupertino as long as it's available. I'd like to thank Connie, W6EFI, and Clark, KK6ISP, for their hard work in organizing and coordinating the soldering project over the last

*(President — Continued on page 3)*

Question
of the
MONTH

On HF, especially on the low bands (e.g., 80m and 40m) what can be done (not considering notch filtering) to reduce noise without losing the ability to hear the signal? (More than one of the following answers may be correct.)

- A) Turn down the volume
- B) Use the noise blanker button
- C) Use the noise reduction button (Some radios allow you to adjust the level of noise reduction.)
- D) Use the RF gain to reduce noise
- E) Add attenuation by 3 dB steps (Some radios do not have the ability to add attenuation in increments – it's either on or off.)
- F) Use noise canceling headphones

Morse Code Resource to get you started

Connie Stillinger, W6EFI

LISTENING AND COPYING

- Your radio – turn it on and listen for morse code qsos, copy what you can. Get on the air when ready.
- websdr, kiwisdr – real radio, online, listen only. <http://websdr1.kfsdr.com:8901/> <http://kiwisdr.com/public/> will get you started.
- Commandline and web
 - ebook2cw infile -o outfile # makes mp3s
 - ARRL code archive <http://www.arrl.org/code-practice-files>

INITIAL LEARNING

Methods

- Searching will turn up many apps, classes and methods. Avoid any that show you dots and dashes!! Anything visual will slow you down. Throw away those cheat sheets on paper (IMO).
- “Farnsworth” = increasing the spacing between characters to slow things down. “Koch” = introducing a few characters at a time while learning. And there are others.
- Be aware that the data on relative effectiveness of any method or class is slim to nonexistent but people have strong opinions about them anyway. Look around and use what is most comfortable and sustainable in terms of regular practice. 5-10 min a day is just fine.
- After initial learning the best way to practice is listen to real qsos or best yet get on the air.

A few learning apps and classes. Free unless otherwise indicated

- Just Learn Morse Code
- K6RAU's Code Course - SKCC Member #11992
- CW Academy: <https://morsecode.world/international/trainer/generator.html>
- G4FON Koch Method CW Trainer
- <https://morsecode.ninja/learn/index.html#MorseCodeCourse>
- <https://longislandcwclub.org/cw-online-classes/> (paid)

PRACTICE COPYING AND/OR GET ON THE AIR!

- General procedures
https://www.skccgroup.com/member_services/beginners_corner/
- POTA/SOTA hunting – very short easy exchange (call, RST, state). Listen for “CQ pota” or “CQ sota”. <https://pota.app> for information.
- K1USN SST (slow speed event) – 2x weekly slow speed, very short exchanges (call, name). Listen for “CQ SST”. <http://www.k1usn.com/sst.html> People will slow down to match your speed. See if you can find K1USN somewhere (always runs 10wpm). Fridays 1-2pm PDT (20:00-21:00 UTC) and Sundays 5-6pm PDT (00:00-01:00 Mon UTC)
- SKCC – free. Scripts, pointers, elmers. they have a page for spotting or scheduling qso's. All keys okay but there are certificates you can work toward for straight key contacts. <https://www.skccgroup.com/>
- CW nets exist! Here are a few: Reno 10am 7.045MHz alt Thurs; Tuolumne 8:30pm 7.053MHz Thurs; SFMARC 8:00pm Tue 3.545MHz. Tune in and see what that's like. Learn some new abbreviations.
- Finding CW to listen to –
 - most common in the bottom 100kHz of each amateur band. 20M is the money band but all bands have some, including 2m and above sometimes!
 - Reverse Beacon Network https://www.reversebeacon.net/main.php?rows=10&max_age=10.hours&modes=cw&hide=distance_km

SOCIAL MEDIA

- PAARA Discord – the # CW-and-morse-code channel
- HRCC Discord – the # dits-and-dahs channel
- etc.

STARTER KEYS

- J38 and SpeedX used keys – solid straight keys, look for them at hamfests and ebay
- CWMorse – okay keys, not too expensive
- Puttikey – reports on these vary
- Vibroplex – decent keys, some have a lot of chrome

(President — Continued from page 1)

several months. In addition to a successful project in September, the club is now set up with materials, tools, and know-how to support future projects that may involve soldering.

The next event to put on your calendar is Pacificon, which is coming up on October 10-12th. Information and registration can be found at <https://www.pacificon.org>. PAARA will again be operating the Special Event station W1AW/6 in the front courtyard of the hotel. Mikko, AB6RF, is overseeing preparations and operation of the station which will be setup starting on Thursday, October 9th. Please let Mikko know if you can help in any way to setup, teardown, or otherwise help operate the station. We'll be managing the station with the club's recently updated computers that Darryl, KI6LDM, has been diligently configuring with all the necessary drivers and software. So plan to come by and help, take a turn at the mic, or just socialize between sessions.

In other news, election season has begun! All officers and directors, except Walt, K6WGY, are up for re-election. I have nominated Clark, KK6ISP, to run the election this year, and he has accepted the appointment. He will need two assistants to help in the nomination and election process as outlined in the bylaws. Please consider volunteering to help Clark with this important process. Nominations will be accepted through the end of the November 7th meeting, and the slate of candidates will be published in the December issue of PAARAgaphs. Elections will be held during the December 5th meeting, and results will be announced at the end of that meeting.

Elections are also currently happening at ARRL. ARRL members will soon be receiving email indicating the voting site for the 2025 ARRL Pacific Division Elections. Online voting for these elections will end at noon (ET), November 21, 2025. I encourage all ARRL members to check the ARRL web site for candidate and election information.

Lastly, you may have seen email from ARRL or the PAARA board about supporting U.S. House and Senate bills that, if passed, will eliminate HOA / private land use restrictions that prohibit Amateur Radio operators from installing anten-

nas at their residence. These bills are collectively known as the "Amateur Radio Emergency Preparedness Act". The ARRL is asking licensed hams (you do not need to be a member of ARRL) to support this legislation by contacting their representative and senators. You can do this by calling their offices, writing a letter or email, or most easily, by visiting <https://send-a-letter.org/HOA/> where you can enter your information, and a letter will be delivered on your behalf. The web site also includes links to the text of the bills so that you can see exactly what is being proposed.

I hope to see you at the next meeting on October 3rd, either in person or on Zoom! We'll have an interesting presentation, some great raffle prizes, and the opportunity to socialize and discuss all our recent activities. If you're there in person, please plan to join us after the official meeting for pizza and lively conversation at Mountain Mike's across the parking lot. We'd love for you to join us!

73, Bob KN6YGN

Get on the air to keep the airwaves alive!

Sept 2025 Board Meeting Minutes

Attending were President Bob Ridenour KN6YGN, Vice President Rob Fenn KC6TYD, Secretary Ric Hulett N6AJS, Treasurer Margaret Cooper K6WEK, board members Darryl Presley KI6LDM, Doug Teter KG6LWE, Walt Gyger K6WEG, and Sorin Constantinescu KN6YUH. Also attending were Clark Martin KK6ISP and Connie Stillinger W6EFI.

The meeting was called to order at 7:02 p.m.

Officer Reports

- President's Report (Bob):
 - We had a really good turnout at the September club meeting: ~20 on Zoom, and the room was essentially full, including 5 new hams!
 - I approved a request from Christopher AI6KG so that he could purchase \$91.23 of cables and adapters for the K3S for Pacificon.
 - Doug reports that he has completed replacing the tires on the tower trailer as ap-

(Minutes — Continued on page 4)

(Minutes — Continued from page 3)

proved at the previous board meeting. The total cost was \$567.88.

- The Zoom account will renew on 10/2 for \$159.90.
- The club Wells Fargo account is now set up to send/receive payments via Zelle.
- Secretary's Report (Ric):
 - The end of the calendar year is approaching: Memberships expire on December 31. Members, now is the time! to renew your membership; it's only \$25.00 per year: See the Secretary at a club meeting, or send a check to PAARA, PO Box 911, Menlo Park CA 94026 or click the 'membership' tab on the PAARA website.
 - I have prepared a spreadsheet listing equipment owned by PAARA. I'll file this in the shared Google drive for the board.
 - I will also move the membership database to the shared drive.
- Treasurer's Report (Margaret):
 - All vendors and suppliers have been paid, including 9 badge orders. Reimbursements for club expenses are going out as approved.
 - We should have a policy on assets: tracking, depreciation, etc. I will review our by-laws for any guidance.
 - The raffle permit application is due in November.
 - I have installed GnuCash as the platform for our account management. I want to give the board a cost and income report for each of our events. The new platform will make that easier.
- VP / Program Chair Report (Rob):
 - Justin AI6YM will be our speaker. Topic is pending input from Justin.

Standing Items

- Every month, we run this message. What is a new way to put it? We need your articles! Member content is the pepperoni on the PAARAGraphs pizza. Please write up your thoughts, such as an interesting ham experience, or a bit of history, for our newsletter.

- Andy (KR6DD) says he's going to write a story for an upcoming issue, and Connie sent in a CW Resources list.
- Education Committee [Darryl]
 - October question of the month:
 - ◆ On HF, especially on the low bands e.g., 80m and 40m, what can be done to reduce noise without losing the ability to hear the signal?
 - PAARA in the Park recap:
 - ◆ PAARA in the Park was a great success. Thanks to the Rangers at Rengstorff park for arranging the rest rooms for us! The soldering project was quite successful.

Congratulations to Connie and Clark for organizing this.

Check out event pictures on the PAARA website.
- IT Subcommittee Updates [Sorin]
 - Club meeting videos are being processed and posted quickly. The September meeting was posted less than 24 hours after the meeting! Thanks Ben, Alan, and Rob.
 - Sorin, Margaret and Ric will develop a workflow for payments through Zelle on our website.
 - How can we make it easier for new members to sign up? Sorin will prototype a google form for new members that will pass data to a spreadsheet.
- PAARAGraphs Advertising [Walt]
 - We can contact Jameco to offer them ad space in PAARAGraphs.
 - Micro Center, Central Computer...Bob to follow up in person at the stores.
- Status of Radio loaner program [Doug]
 - A local ham, Frank K6FCW, has donated a Yaesu FT-897 to the club. We now have three transceivers that are available to members.

We'll promote this program with a spot in PAARAGraphs.

Old Business

- New computer purchase:

(Minutes — Continued on page 5)

(Minutes — Continued from page 4)

- o Bob (KN6YGN) purchased 5x Dell Latitude 5420 refurbished laptops. These are equipped with Windows 11 Pro, Intel I5 processor, 16 GB RAM, and 512 GB SSD. The total cost was \$1441.80, well under budget.
- o Darryl has updated all laptops with new USB drivers and N1MM+ logger. These will be ready for Pacificon.
- PAARA (thanks to KC6TYD) received \$704 from equipment sales at the Flea Market!
- New ham links: 30 postcards were sent to new hams. There are about 30 to 35 new hams per month in the area.

New Business

- We discussed a policy for cancellations for events like PAARA in the Park. We may adopt a policy allowing refunds up to 48

hours before the event, depending on the costs involved.

- PAARA Officer and Director elections (December). Clark KK6ISP has agreed to serve as elections committee chair.
- Dream to Reality Raffle (December)
 - o Again this year, our big raffle prize will be an Elecraft KX3. A representative from Elecraft will be our guest speaker for the December meeting.
- Alexia Snethen KM6LGG has received the Goldfarb Memorial Scholarship from ARRL. Congratulations to her!

The meeting was adjourned at 9:09 pm

Respectfully submitted,

Ric Hulett N6AJS
PAARA Secretary

- 5th OLIGHT IMINI 2 EDC Re-chargeable Key-chain Flashlight, 50 Lumens Compact and Portable Mini LED Keyring Light + "Transmitter Hunting" book.



- 4th MOLLE Pouch First Aid Kit



- 3rd Surecom SF-103 Handheld 2mHz - 2.8GHz Walkie Talkie 2-Way Radio Frequency Counter



- 2nd Out of the box PicoFox is a great little fox transmitter for the 2-meter amateur band.



- 1st Retevis RA89 Ham Radio, Dual Band Handheld Radio, IP68 Water-proof Two Way Radio, 2500mAh USB-C



September Raffle Winners (left to right):
Ben (KN6UBF), Sorin (KN6YUH),
Bob (KN6YGN), Rusty (KM7BZS),
John (N6YU)

PAARAgaphs — October 2025
Celebrating 88 years as an active ham radio club—Since 1937



Waiting for delicious burgers!



Enjoying great conversation and stories.



Where is that fox?!?



Mentors help participants with solder projects.



Making some QRP contacts.

Palo Alto Amateur Radio Association, Inc.

PO Box 911 Menlo Park, CA 94026

Officers

President	Bob Ridenour, KN6YGN	650-575-4528
	kn6ygn@paara.org	
Vice President	Rob Fenn, KC6TYD	650-888-9060
	kc6tyd@paara.org	
Secretary	Ric Hulett, N6AJS	408-332-4593
	n6ajs@paara.org	
Treasurer	Margaret Cooper, K6WEK	
	k6wek@paara.org	

Directors

Director ('24-'25)	Sorin Constantinescu, KN6YUH,	
	kn6yuh@paara.org	
Director ('25-'26)	Walt Gyger, K6WGY	408-921-5901
	k6wgy@paara.org	
Director ('25)	Doug Teter, KG6LWE	650-743-7892
	kg6lwe@paara.org	
Director ('25)	Darryl Presley, KI6LDM	650 255-2454
	ki6ldm@paara.org	

Appointed Positions

Membership	Ric Hulett, N6AJS	408-332-4593
	n6ajs@paara.org	
Database	Ric Hulett, N6AJS	408-332-4593
	n6ajs@paara.org	
Station Trustee	K6OTA SORIN CONSTANTINESCU,	
	KN6YUH	
Property Manager	Doug Teter, KG6LWE	
Badge Coordinator	Doug Teter, KG6LWE	650-743-7892
	kg6lwe@paara.org	
Raffle Coordinator	Rob Fenn, KC6TYD,	
	kc6tyd@paara.org	
Field Day Coordinator	Doug Teter, KG6LWE	650-743-7892
ASVARO Rep	Clark Martin, KK6ISP	
	kk6isp@sonic.net	
Webmasters	webmaster@paara.org	
Technical Coordinator	Christopher, AI6KG	408-348-0304
	ch@murgatroid.com	
QSL Manager	Ric Hulett, N6AJS	408-332-4593
Speaker Coordinator ...	Rob Fenn, kc6tyd	650-888-9060

PAARAgaphs Staff

Editorial Board		
	Bob Van Tuyl K6RWY	Jim Thielemann K6SV
	Bob Ridenour KN6YGN	Doug Teter KG6LWE
	Sorin Constantinescu KN6YUH	
Editor	Bob Van Tuyl, K6RWY	408 799-6463
	rrvt@swde.com	
Back Up Editor	Jim Thielemann, K6SV	408-839-6815
	thielem@pacbell.net	
Advertising	Walt Gyger, K6WGY	408-921-5901
	k6wgy@paara.org	
Technical Tips	Ric Hulett, N6AJS	

VE Exams

De Anza Park, Sunnyvale, 2nd Saturday 10:30 am each month except November and December. See website for details and exceptions: <http://amateur-radio.org>

Electronics Flea Market (EFM)

Sponsorship: Association of Silicon Valley Amateur Radio Organizations (ASVARO). The Electronics Flea Market is held at West Valley College, 14000 Fruitvale Ave, Saratoga.
Website: <http://www.electronicfleamarket.com/>

PAARA — Palo Alto Amateur Radio Association

Meets 1st Friday 7:00pm each month at Room H-6, Cubberley Community Center; Net 145.230 - PL 100Hz Mondays at 8:30. See website at <http://www.paara.org>. For more information. contact: Joel Wilhite KD6W, kd6w@arri.net, 650-325-8239

FARS — Foothills Amateur Radio Society

Meets 4th Friday each month at 7:00pm at Covington School, Los Altos.
Website: <http://www.fars.k6ya.org>

NCDXC — Northern California DX Club

Meets 3rd Thursday 7:00pm each month,
Repeater for member info 147.360. Contact president@ncdxc.org. Website: <http://ncdxc.org>. YouTube content: "The Northern California DX Club Official Channel". Cohost of the International DX Convention.

The 50MHz & Up Group of Northern California

This organization specializes in vhf + wak signal and microwave activities. Meetings are held on the first Tuesday of each month. Time is usually 5pm for in person meetings, and 7pm for Zoom only meetings. In person meetings are held Sports Basement, 1177 Kern Ave, Sunnyvale. Always check the website, <http://50MhzandUp.org>, for correct information. Zoom information is also there.

San Mateo Radio Club W6UQ.ORG

Meets, 3rd Friday, January through November.
Tuesdays & Thursdays, [Directed] Net, 7pm, N6ZX 145.370Hz, -600KHz, PL107.2Hz
Contact: SanMateoRadioClub@gmail.com, Website: <http://W6UQ.org/calendar>

SPECS

Southern Peninsula Emergency Communication System users Group

Meets each Monday 7:30pm and 8:00pm.
See: <https://specsnet.org/monday-night-net> for more info.
Contact: <https://www.specsnet.org/contact> or board@specsnet.org

SCARES

South County Amateur Radio Emergency Service

Meets 3rd Thursday 7:30pm each month, Belmont EOC, Belmont City Hall, One Twin Pines Lane, Belmont CA 94002. Net is on 146.445 [PL 114.8] & 444.50 (PL-100) 7:30 Monday evenings. Contact: President Gary D. Aden, K6GDA 650-743-1265 (D), 650-595-5590 (N)
Web: <http://k6mpn.org> E-mail: pres@k6mpn.org

SCCARRA

Santa Clara County Amateur Radio Association

Operates W6UU & W6UU/R, repeater 146.985-pl
Nets: 2m, 7:30pm Mon; 70cm, 10M (28.385) 8PM Thur.
Meets 2nd Mon each month @ 7:30 PM.
ARRL/VEC license testing contact 408-507-4698

SVECS — Silicon Valley Emergency Communications

Operates AA6BT repeater (146.115 MHz+)
Website: <http://www.svecs.net> or contact: Lou Stierer WA6QYS 408 241 7999

WVARA — West Valley Amateur Radio Association

W6PIY six-meter repeater on 52.58MHz. Normally, six-meters is linked with 147 and 223, while 441 and 1286 repeaters are linked.

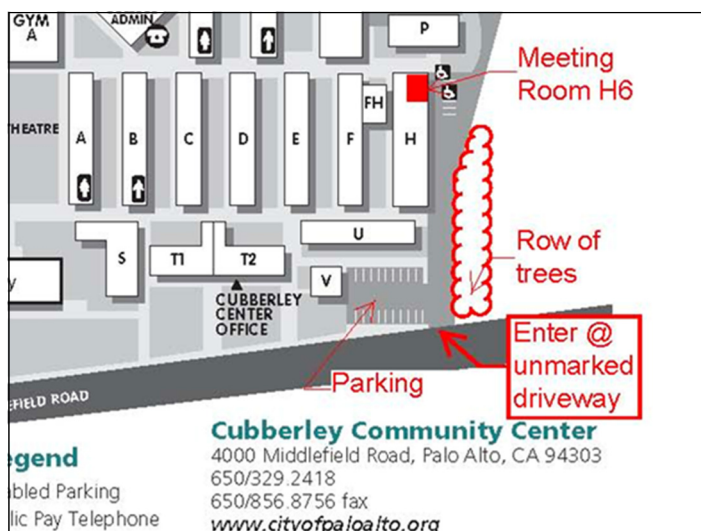
VHF: 52.58	(-500) 151.4 ctcss	UHF:		
147.39	(+600) 151.4 ctcss		441.35	(+5.0) 88.5 ctcss
223.96	(+1.6) 156.7 ctcss		1286.20	(-12m) 100.0 ctcss

Meetings are 2nd Wednesday of every month except July, August and December.

Website: <http://wvara.org>. Contact: info@wvara.org

(Please send changes to PAARAgaphs editor)

This space is available



**Meeting Location — Middlefield Road
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Palo Alto Amateur Radio Association P.O. Box 911, Menlo Park California 94026-0911

Club meetings are on the first Friday of each month,
 7:00pm at the Room H-6, Cubberley Community Center.

Radio NET & Swap Session every Monday evening, at
 8:30pm, on the 145.230 –600 MHz repeater, PL 100Hz.

Membership in PAARA is \$25.00 per calendar year,
 which includes one subscription to PAARAgaphs
 \$6 for each additional family member (no newsletter).

Make payment to the
 Palo Alto Amateur Radio Association,
 P.O. Box 911, Menlo Park, CA 94026-0911

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PAARA Weekly Radio Net

Info and Swap Session
 every Monday evening at 8:30pm
 on the N6NFI 145.230 MHz repeater

Week Control Operator

1 st	Doug - KG6LWE
2 nd	Doug - KG6LWE
3 rd	Ric - N6AJS
4 th	Rob - KC6TYD
5 th	Rob - KC6TYD

If you're interested in trying out at Net Control, Con-
 tact Doug, KG6LWE. It's good practice, and lots
 o' fun! Give it a try.

ARV'S, WA6UUT (SK)
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UHF DMR	444.475 MHz +5 MHz CC1	Slot 1: Dynamic Slot 2: NorCal BM (31068)
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PAARA Badges
Badges can be ordered through
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the bottom of the page and fill out
the info. All badges will be mailed.
The cost for a badge is \$30.00.

PAARAgaphs Ad Rates
PAARAgaphs accepts paid advertisements from non-members. (short personal ads remain free for members in good standing). **All ad rates listed are per issue.**
1. Not-for-profit ads by association members for ham-related items and wants. No cost for business card-size ads (additional space at \$2.50 per business card size per issue).
2. For Profit organizations and/or individuals: \$5-business card size, \$14.00-quarter page, \$25-half page, \$50 full page or back cover per issue.
These fees may be reduced or waived in exchange for a valuable consideration that is given to the Association or its general membership. Such consideration must be in addition to any existing arrangements with the association. The PAARAgaphs editors reserve the right to reject any ad deemed to be not in the best interest of the Association.
All fees payable in advance by the year with "scanner-ready" copy or text-only ads. **Give payment and copy to Walt Gyger, K6WGY.**

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- Scope Displays 3-Dimensional Spectrum Stream



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FI-691 | HF+50 MHz All Mode Mobile Transceiver
Stable 100 Watt Output • 32-Bit IF DSP • Large Dot Matrix LCD
Display with Quick Spectrum Scope • USB Port Allows Connection to a PC with a Single Cable • CAT Control, PTT/TRTTY Control



FI-3185KASP | Heavy-Duty 85W 2M FM Transceiver



FTM-150RASP | 2M/430MHz FM True Dual Band Xcvr



FTM-510DRASP CqFM/FTM 144/430MHz Dual Band New

- New Super-DX & ASP (Audio Digital Signal Processor Unit) • True Dual Bank Receive (V+VU+UV+UVU+V) • CqFM/CqFM Digital D-D • Dual Receive • 2.4" High-Res Full-Color Touch-Panel Display • Wireless Operation Capability with Optional Bluetooth® Headset

- BigRadio Features in a Compact Package
- Wide-band Receiver Coverage for Catching All the Action! • 900-Channel, 24-Bands Memory System
- Outdoor-Ready Features including Waterproofing
- Rating • Smart Search Automatic 31-Channel Scanning/Loading System



FI-65H | 144.450 MHz Transceiver

- Compact, Commercial Grade, Rugged Design
- Large Front Speaker Delivers 1W of Powerful Clear Audio
- 5 Watts of Reliable RF Power With-In a compact Body
- 3.5-Hour Rapid Charger Included
- Large White LED Flashlight, Alarm and Quick Home Channel Access



F550R CAFE/MEM 144/430 MHz Dual Band

- High-Res Full-Color Touch Screen TFT LCD Display
- Easy Hands-Free Operation w/Built-In Bluetooth® Unit
- Built-In High-Precision GPS Antenna
- 1,200/6000bps AMPS Data Communications
- Supports Simultaneous CAFE Digital Micro SD Card Slot



- System Fusion Compatible • Large Front Speaker delivers 700 mW of Loud Audio Output
- Automatic Mode Select: detects C4FM or Fm Analog and Switches Accordingly • Huge 1,105 Channel Memory Capacity • External DC Jack for DC Supply and Battery Charging



FT-60R | *VHF/UHF Rugged Dual Band*

- Over 1000 Memory Channels • Wide Band
- Receiver Coverage • High Power Output: 5 Watts
- Huge LCD Display • NOAA Severe Weather Alert
- with Alert Scan

5 Ways
to Shop!

- RETAIL LOCATIONS - Store hours 10:00AM - 5:30PM
- PHONE - Toll-free phone hours 9:30AM - 5:30PM
- ONLINE - WWW.HAMRADIO.COM

- **FAX** – All store locations
- **MAIL** – All store locations

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